(606–648 CE), whose biography, the *Harshacarita*, was composed in his own lifetime. Harshavardhana is known to have authored dramas and epigraphs, and his court was visited and described in all its richness by the Chinese pilgrim Xuanzang. The sources for writing about him are therefore, relatively speaking, richer, resulting in a variety of biographical and regnal studies.[29] On balance, though, there is much truth in Ramachandra Guha's view that 'the art of biography remains underdeveloped in South Asia.'[30] Perhaps the only scholar of ancient India whose books represent an exception to this perspective is the historian-politician Radhakumud Mookerji, who wrote voluminously and valuably on ancient kings, most notably books on Chandragupta Maurya, Ashoka, and Harshavardhana.

Considering the general dearth of biographical interest in ancient India's royal *dramatis personae*, how may one explain the popularity of Ashoka? In large part this is because of his own keenness to appear to posterity as neither recondite nor imperious but instead as a flesh-and-blood emperor guided less by power than by compassion. Among rulers Ashoka is so exceptional in being upfront about sharing his grief that it is difficult not to empathize with him. An ancient sovereign who took responsibility for a politically reprehensible action, he seems at times less a political figure than a strikingly self-reflective individual. The contrast with the archetypically self-serving politician is so stark and rare that Ashoka arouses in historians a knee-jerk admiration virtually unseen in South Asia until the appearance of Mahatma Gandhi.[31]

Gandhi is also relevant for another reason. Indian nationalist leaders and thinkers who fought the Raj under him and forged the structure of an independent nation sought to image Ashoka as their political fountainhead. India's long lineage of tolerance and non-violence was seen as stretching back to the Buddha and, from the perspective of the nationalist imagination, the temptation to assume the mantle of Ashoka as a model of humane rulership was strong.[32] Tagore made this connection when he noted that